

Hamilton, ON to Yellowstone National Park Road Trip Itinerary

Trip Duration: July 4 – July 18, 2026 (15 Days, 14 Nights)
Travelers: 2 Adults (Couple)
Vehicle: Mitsubishi Outlander PHEV

Trip Overview

Route Summary

- **Outbound Route:** Hamilton → Michigan → Wisconsin → South Dakota → Wyoming → Yellowstone
- **Return Route:** Yellowstone → South Dakota → Iowa → Illinois → Chicago (overnight) → Michigan → Ontario
- **Total Distance:** ~5,700 km round trip
- **National Parks Pass:** America the Beautiful Annual Pass — \$80 USD (~\$110 CAD) — Valid for 1 vehicle and all passengers

Key Highlights

- Badlands & Wind Cave National Parks
- Mount Rushmore & Crazy Horse Memorial
- Devils Tower National Monument
- Grand Teton National Park
- Yellowstone National Park (3 nights)
- Chicago downtown overnight (Day 13)
- Multiple scenic drives with minimal trekking
- Cedar Rapids overnight option (flexible)

Day-by-Day Itinerary

Day 1: Saturday, July 4, 2026

Route: Hamilton, ON → Mackinaw City, MI
Distance: 650 km | **Driving Time:** 6.5 hours

Canada Day Note: This is now Independence Day in the USA — expect busier border crossings. Cross early.

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart Hamilton 9:00 AM ET
- **Lunch Stop:** Windsor/Sarnia border crossing (~2 hours); cross into Detroit via Ambassador Bridge or Blue Water Bridge

- **Afternoon:** Drive through Michigan — optional quick stop at Port Huron beach
- **Evening:** Arrive Mackinaw City (~4:30 PM ET)
 - Walk along the waterfront
 - View Mackinac Bridge at sunset
 - Visit Colonial Michilimackinac State Park (if time permits)

 Walking Distances — Mackinaw City

Viewpoint / Attraction	Parking → Viewpoint	Notes
Mackinac Bridge viewpoint	~150 m from waterfront lot	Flat, paved — easy stroll
Colonial Michilimackinac entrance	~100 m from park parking	Compact grounds; ~500 m total inside
Port Huron beach (optional)	~50 m from roadside pullout	Drive-up access, minimal walking

 **Tip to reduce walking:** The bridge and waterfront are all within 200 m of each other — park once near the waterfront and walk to all three.

Accommodation

Super 8 by Wyndham Mackinaw City
Address: 519 S Nicolet St, Mackinaw City, MI 49701
Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast, Wi-Fi
Rate: \$95 USD/night (~\$131 CAD)

Dining

- **Lunch:** Border area — Tim Hortons or quick stop (~\$25 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Mackinaw Grille, Mackinaw City — entrees \$15–25 USD/person (~\$60 USD / ~\$83 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$131
Meals	\$108
Gas (~60L @ \$1.60/L)	\$96
Border toll	\$5
Daily Total	\$340

Day 2: Sunday, July 5, 2026

Route: Mackinaw City, MI → Wisconsin Dells, WI
Distance: 630 km | **Driving Time:** 6.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart 8:30 AM; cross Mackinac Bridge (\$4 USD toll)
- **En Route:** Drive through Upper Peninsula Michigan & Wisconsin; stop at Menominee River scenic overlook
- **Afternoon:** Arrive Wisconsin Dells (~3:00 PM CT)
 - Visit Mirror Lake State Park (free, natural beauty)
 - Walk through downtown Dells
 - Optional: Witches Gulch or Lost Canyon tours (\$15–20 USD pp)

Walking Distances — Wisconsin Dells

Viewpoint / Attraction	Parking → Viewpoint	Notes
Mirror Lake State Park overlook	~200 m from main lot	Flat, paved path
Downtown Dells main strip	~100 m from street parking	Compact, walkable
Witches Gulch (optional)	~500 m one-way boat + boardwalk	Mostly flat boardwalk
Lost Canyon (optional)	~600 m canyon walk	Flat canyon floor

 **Tip to reduce walking:** Skip Witches Gulch/Lost Canyon if tired — the downtown stroll and Mirror Lake are fully scenic with under 400 m walking total.

Accommodation

Days Inn by Wyndham Wisconsin Dells

Address: 944 Highway 13, Wisconsin Dells, WI 53965

Features: Free breakfast, Wi-Fi, outdoor pool

Rate: \$88 USD/night (~\$121 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Roadside stop in Wisconsin (~\$30 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Moosejaw Pizza & Dells Brewing Co. (~\$55 USD / ~\$76 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$121
Meals	\$106
Gas (~57L @ \$1.60/L)	\$91
Mackinac Bridge toll	\$6
Optional tour (if taken)	\$55

Item	Cost (CAD)
Daily Total	\$324 (or \$379 with tour)

Day 3: Monday, July 6, 2026

Route: Wisconsin Dells, WI → Rapid City, SD

Distance: 770 km | **Driving Time:** 7.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart 8:00 AM CT; drive through Minnesota & South Dakota
- **Lunch:** Mitchell, SD — see the Corn Palace (free, quirky roadside attraction)
- **Evening:** Arrive Rapid City (~4:30 PM MT)
 - Walk around downtown Rapid City
 - City of Presidents walking tour (free bronze statues)

 Walking Distances — Rapid City

Viewpoint / Attraction	Parking → Viewpoint	Notes
Corn Palace exterior (Mitchell)	~50 m from street parking	Roadside — minimal walking
City of Presidents statues, downtown	~100 m from Main St parking	Statues are spread ~1 km along streets; do a short loop of 4–5 closest ones (~400 m)

 **Tip to reduce walking:** Drive the City of Presidents route slowly and hop out only for statues that interest you most — all are within 50 m of the road.

Accommodation

Fairfield Inn & Suites Rapid City

Address: 1314 N Elk Vale Rd, Rapid City, SD 57703

Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast, indoor pool

Rate: \$105 USD/night (~\$145 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Corn Palace Café, Mitchell, SD (~\$28 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Tally's Silver Spoon, Rapid City (~\$50 USD / ~\$69 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$145

Item	Cost (CAD)
Meals	\$97
Gas (~70L @ \$1.60/L)	\$112
Daily Total	\$354

Day 4: Tuesday, July 7, 2026

Route: Rapid City, SD (Day Trip Loop)
Distance: 240 km loop | **Driving Time:** 5 hours total (with stops)

Attractions & Stops — FULL DAY OF SIGHTSEEING

Morning:

- **Mount Rushmore National Memorial** (1.5–2 hours) — Entry included in America the Beautiful Pass (otherwise \$10 parking)
- **Custer State Park** (2–3 hours) — Wildlife Loop Road scenic drive; Needles Highway; Sylvan Lake area — Entry: \$20 USD/vehicle (~\$28 CAD)

Afternoon:

- **Crazy Horse Memorial** (1 hour) — Entry: \$15 USD/person (~\$41 CAD for two)
- Return to Rapid City via Iron Mountain Road (scenic tunnels framing Mount Rushmore)

 Walking Distances — Day 4 Sightseeing

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Notes
Mount Rushmore — Grand View Terrace	Main visitor parking	~250 m from parking to terrace	Paved, gentle incline; this is all you need
Mount Rushmore — Presidential Trail	Same parking	~800 m loop (adds closer views)	Optional; mostly flat with some steps — skip if preferred
Custer State Park — Wildlife Loop	Drive-in scenic road	0 m — view from car windows	Bison, pronghorn, burros roadside
Needles Highway granite spires	Cathedral Spires trailhead pullout	~0–50 m roadside pullouts	Drive-through; tunnels are the main attraction
Sylvan Lake (optional)	Sylvan Lake parking	~300 m easy lakeside loop	Flat, paved — very scenic; skip if short on time
Crazy Horse Memorial	Visitor center lot	~100 m to terrace viewpoint	All viewing from terrace; no trail needed
Iron Mountain Road pigtail bridges	Roadside pullouts	~0–100 m from car	Drive slowly and stop at tunnels for framed Rushmore views

● **Optimized Low-Walking Route for Day 4:**

1. Mount Rushmore → walk only to Grand View Terrace (250 m, ~10 min) — skip Presidential Trail
2. Drive Wildlife Loop Road in Custer SP (pure car experience)
3. Drive Needles Highway — stop at 2–3 pullouts only (under 100 m each)
4. Crazy Horse → terrace viewpoint (100 m)
5. Iron Mountain Road back — tunnel photo stops only

Total walking for the day: under 700 m while seeing everything.

Accommodation

Fairfield Inn & Suites Rapid City (same as previous night)

Rate: \$105 USD/night (~\$145 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** State Game Lodge, Custer State Park — buffalo burger! (~\$45 USD / ~\$62 CAD for two)
- **Dinner:** Murphy's Pub & Grill, Rapid City (~\$48 USD / ~\$66 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$145
Meals	\$128
Gas (~22L @ \$1.60/L)	\$35
Custer State Park entry	\$28
Crazy Horse entry	\$41
Daily Total	\$377

Day 5: Wednesday, July 8, 2026

Route: Rapid City, SD → Cody, WY

Distance: 560 km | **Driving Time:** 6 hours

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- **Badlands National Park** (2–3 hours) — Entry included in America the Beautiful Pass
 - Drive Badlands Loop Road (Hwy 240) — 31 miles of scenic overlooks
 - Stop at: Pinnacles Overlook, Yellow Mounds, Panorama Point, Big Badlands Overlook

Afternoon:

- **Devils Tower National Monument** (1.5 hours) — Entry included in America the Beautiful Pass
- **Evening:** Arrive Cody, WY

Walking Distances — Day 5 Sightseeing

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Viewpoint	Notes
Badlands — Big Badlands Overlook	Roadside pullout	~30 m from car	Best panoramic view; drive-up
Badlands — Pinnacles Overlook	Pinnacles Overlook lot	~50 m from car	Flat gravel path
Badlands — Yellow Mounds Overlook	Roadside pullout	~20 m from car	Drive-up pullout
Badlands — Panorama Point	Small lot	~50 m from car	Flat, paved
Badlands — Door Trail boardwalk (optional)	Ben Reifel Visitor Center lot	0.75 km boardwalk (flat)	Fully accessible; great canyon views
Badlands — Fossil Exhibit Trail (optional)	Fossil Exhibit pullout	0.4 km paved loop	Fully flat; fossils under glass
Devils Tower — viewpoint from parking area	Tower Trail lot	~200 m to best view angle	Flat paved path
Devils Tower — Red Beds Trail partial (optional)	Same lot	1.5 km partial loop	Mostly flat; great alternate angles — do first 400 m only for extra views

Optimized Low-Walking Route for Day 5:

- Badlands: Drive Loop Road and stop at 4–5 pullouts (all under 50 m from car). Add Door Trail boardwalk only if energized (0.75 km flat).
- Devils Tower: Walk 200 m to main viewpoint from parking. Optionally add 400 m of Red Beds for tower-close view. Skip full loop.
- **Total walking: 400–900 m for the full day.**

Accommodation

Hampton Inn Cody

Address: 1807 Sheridan Ave, Cody, WY 82414

Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast, indoor pool

Rate: \$115 USD/night (~\$159 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Cedar Pass Lodge, Badlands or packed sandwiches (~\$35 CAD)

- **Dinner:** Wyoming's Rib & Chop House, Cody (~\$60 USD / ~\$83 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$159
Meals	\$118
Gas (~51L @ \$1.60/L)	\$82
Daily Total	\$359

Day 6: Thursday, July 9, 2026

Route: Cody, WY → West Yellowstone, MT
Distance: 200 km | **Driving Time:** 2.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- **Buffalo Bill Center of the West**, Cody (2–3 hours) — Entry: \$21 USD/person (~\$58 CAD for two) — 5 museums in one

Afternoon:

- Scenic drive to West Yellowstone through Shoshone National Forest
- Stop at Yellowstone Lake overlooks

Evening: Arrive West Yellowstone; walk around town

 Walking Distances — Day 6

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Viewpoint	Notes
Buffalo Bill Center of the West	On-site lot	~50 m to entrance	All indoor — no terrain concern
Shoshone National Forest overlooks	Roadside pullouts	~20–50 m from car	Drive-up viewpoints
Yellowstone Lake overlooks (en route)	Roadside pullouts	~30–50 m from car	Spectacular lake views; drive-up

Accommodation

Stage Coach Inn — West Yellowstone
Address: 209 Madison Ave, West Yellowstone, MT 59758

Features: Level 2 EV charging (ChargePoint), free breakfast, hot tub
Rate: \$135 USD/night (~\$186 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Quick bite in Cody before departure (~\$30 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Wild West Pizzeria & Saloon, West Yellowstone (~\$55 USD / ~\$76 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$186
Meals	\$106
Gas (~18L @ \$1.60/L)	\$29
Buffalo Bill Center entry	\$58
Daily Total	\$379

Day 7: Friday, July 10, 2026

YELLOWSTONE NATIONAL PARK — Day 1 (Lower Loop)
Distance: 150 km in park | **Driving Time:** Full day with stops

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- Enter Yellowstone West Entrance (7:00 AM — beat crowds!)
- **Lower Geyser Basin — Fountain Paint Pot**
- **Midway Geyser Basin — Grand Prismatic Spring**
- **Old Faithful area**

Afternoon:

- **West Thumb Geyser Basin** on Yellowstone Lake
- Drive along Yellowstone Lake shore
- **Lake Butte Overlook**

Evening: Return to West Yellowstone

 **Walking Distances — Yellowstone Day 1**

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Full Loop	Recommendation
Fountain Paint Pot, Lower Geyser Basin	Fountain Paint Pot lot	~100 m to boardwalk start	0.8 km loop (flat)	✅ Do the full loop — all flat boardwalk, multiple features
Grand Prismatic Spring, Midway Geyser Basin	Midway Geyser Basin lot	~50 m to boardwalk	0.8 km loop (flat)	✅ Do the full loop — THE highlight, completely flat
Grand Prismatic Overlook Trail (optional)	Fairy Falls trailhead, 0.8 km south	1.3 km uphill each way	—	⚠️ Skip — aerial view is great but significant uphill; the boardwalk at ground level is equally impressive
Old Faithful Geyser	Old Faithful Visitor Center lot	~200 m to viewing benches	—	✅ Watch from benches — 200 m flat walk from car
Upper Geyser Basin boardwalk	Old Faithful lot	~200 m to start of boardwalk	1–3 km depending on extension	✅ Do first 800 m to Beehive/Castle/Riverside Geysers; skip extension to Morning Glory Pool (adds 2 km)
Morning Glory Pool (optional extension)	Old Faithful lot	~2.4 km one-way	—	⚠️ Skip — pool is beautiful but very long walk; not worth it on a packed day
West Thumb Geyser Basin	West Thumb lot	~50 m to boardwalk	0.9 km loop (flat)	✅ Do the full loop — lakeside thermal features, fully flat
Lake Butte Overlook	Roadside pullout (6 km past fishing bridge)	~50 m from car	—	✅ Drive-up viewpoint

● Optimized Low-Walking Route for Day 7:

1. Fountain Paint Pot — 0.8 km flat loop ✅
2. Grand Prismatic Spring — 0.8 km flat loop ✅ (skip overlook trail)
3. Old Faithful — 200 m to benches; watch eruption ✅
4. Upper Geyser Basin — walk 800 m only (to Riverside Geyser) ✅
5. West Thumb Geyser Basin — 0.9 km flat loop ✅
6. Lake Butte Overlook — drive-up ✅

Total walking: ~3.5 km across the entire day (all flat boardwalks).

Accommodation

Stage Coach Inn — West Yellowstone (same hotel)

Rate: \$135 USD/night (~\$186 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Packed sandwiches/snacks (buy groceries evening before) (~\$25 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Running Bear Pancake House, West Yellowstone (~\$50 USD / ~\$69 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$186
Meals	\$94
Gas (~14L @ \$1.60/L)	\$22
Groceries for next day	\$30
Daily Total	\$332

Day 8: Saturday, July 11, 2026

YELLOWSTONE NATIONAL PARK — Day 2 (Upper Loop)

Distance: 180 km in park | **Driving Time:** Full day with stops

Note: July 4th has passed — this weekend is still peak summer but crowds are more manageable. Start early (6:00 AM) regardless.

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- Depart 6:00 AM
- **Norris Geyser Basin**
- **Mammoth Hot Springs**

Afternoon:

- **Tower-Roosevelt area** (scenic drive)
- **Grand Canyon of the Yellowstone**

Evening:

- **Hayden Valley** — prime wildlife viewing

 Walking Distances — Yellowstone Day 2

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Full Option	Recommendation
Norris Geyser Basin — Porcelain Basin	Norris lot	~100 m to boardwalk start	0.8 km loop (flat)	✅ Do Porcelain Basin loop — the most dramatic, all flat
Norris Geyser Basin — Back Basin	Same lot	~150 m to boardwalk start	1.5 km loop (mostly flat)	⚠️ Optional — skip or do first 400 m to Steamboat Geyser only
Mammoth Hot Springs — Lower Terraces	Lower Terraces lot	~50 m to boardwalk	0.6 km loop (flat)	✅ Do the Lower Terraces — most colourful, fully flat
Mammoth Hot Springs — Upper Terraces	Upper Terraces one-way road (drive)	~100 m per pullout	Drive-through loop	✅ Drive the one-way upper terrace road — park at pullouts, walk 50–100 m to each terrace
Grand Canyon of Yellowstone — Artist Point	Artist Point lot	~150 m paved path to viewpoint	—	✅ Must-do — iconic falls view, 150 m flat walk
Grand Canyon — Lookout Point	North Rim lot	~200 m to canyon rim	—	✅ Great secondary view, 200 m easy walk
Grand Canyon — Brink of Lower Falls (optional)	Brink lot	0.5 km downhill then back up	—	⚠️ Skip — steep and strenuous; Artist Point gives equal drama
Uncle Tom's Trail	South Rim lot	328 steps down + back up	—	❌ Skip — very strenuous
Hayden Valley wildlife pullouts	Multiple roadside pullouts	0–30 m from car	—	✅ View bison herds from car or roadside

● Optimized Low-Walking Route for Day 8:

1. Norris — Porcelain Basin loop (0.8 km flat) ✅
2. Mammoth — Lower Terraces loop (0.6 km flat) + drive Upper Terraces ✅
3. Grand Canyon — Artist Point (150 m) + Lookout Point (200 m) ✅
4. Hayden Valley — wildlife from car windows ✅

Total walking: ~1.8 km for the entire day.

Accommodation

Stage Coach Inn — West Yellowstone (same hotel)

Rate: \$135 USD/night (~\$186 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel (early buffet)
- **Lunch:** Packed lunch from groceries (\$0 — already purchased)
- **Dinner:** Serenity Bistro, West Yellowstone (~\$58 USD / ~\$80 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$186
Meals	\$80
Gas (~16L @ \$1.60/L)	\$26
Daily Total	\$292

Day 9: Sunday, July 12, 2026

YELLOWSTONE + GRAND TETON — Day 3

Route: West Yellowstone → Jackson, WY

Distance: 180 km | **Driving Time:** 4 hours with stops

Attractions & Stops

Morning:

- Early start (7:00 AM)
- **Lamar Valley** — wildlife viewing ("Serengeti of North America")
- OR revisit favourite Yellowstone spots from previous days

Afternoon:

- Exit Yellowstone South Entrance
- **Grand Teton National Park** (3–4 hours) — Entry included in America the Beautiful Pass

Evening: Arrive Jackson

 Walking Distances — Grand Teton Day

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Full Option	Recommendation
Lamar Valley wildlife viewing	Multiple roadside pullouts	0–30 m from car	—	✔ View from car or roadside; no walking needed

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Full Option	Recommendation
Jenny Lake scenic area	Jenny Lake South lot	~200 m to lakefront	1 km lakefront walk	✔ Walk 200 m to water's edge for stunning Teton reflection; skip full loop
Snake River Overlook	Roadside pullout (Hwy 89)	~30 m from car	—	✔ Drive-up; Ansel Adams viewpoint — iconic
Schwabacher Landing	Schwabacher Rd lot	~200 m to riverbank	—	✔ Flat gravel path; excellent reflection photography
Mormon Row Historic District — T.A. Moulton Barn	Roadside parking	~50 m from car	—	✔ Drive-up; walk to barn for foreground shots
Oxbow Bend	Roadside pullout	~30 m from car	—	✔ Drive-up; stunning reflection viewpoint

● **Optimized Low-Walking Route for Day 9 (Grand Teton):**

- 1. Lamar Valley — car windows ✔
- 2. Snake River Overlook — 30 m walk ✔
- 3. Schwabacher Landing — 200 m flat walk ✔
- 4. Jenny Lake — 200 m to lakefront ✔
- 5. Mormon Row Barn — 50 m walk ✔
- 6. Oxbow Bend — 30 m walk ✔

Total walking: ~540 m across 5 iconic Grand Teton viewpoints.

Accommodation

Elk Country Inn — Jackson Hole

Address: 480 W Pearl Ave, Jackson, WY 83001

Features: Free breakfast, Wi-Fi

Rate: \$125 USD/night (~\$172 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Packed snacks from groceries
- **Dinner:** Bubba’s Bar-B-Que, Jackson (~\$55 USD / ~\$76 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$172
Meals	\$76
Gas (~16L @ \$1.60/L)	\$26
Daily Total	\$274

Day 10: Monday, July 13, 2026

Route: Jackson, WY → Custer, SD
Distance: 750 km | **Driving Time:** 7.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart Jackson 8:00 AM; quick walk around Jackson Town Square (elk antler arches)
- **En Route:** Long driving day through Wyoming and into South Dakota; lunch stop in Lusk or Newcastle, WY
- **Afternoon:** Wind Cave National Park (if time permits — 1–2 hours) — Entry included; cave tours \$15 USD pp
- **Evening:** Arrive Custer, SD

 Walking Distances — Day 10

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Viewpoint	Notes
Jackson Town Square elk antler arches	Town Square lot	~50 m to square centre	Quick and flat
Wind Cave NP — prairie dog viewpoint	Visitor center lot	~100 m to overlook	Optional; flat path
Wind Cave NP — cave tour (optional)	Visitor center lot	Guided tour only (0.8 km underground)	Book ahead; moderate

Accommodation

Comfort Inn & Suites Custer
Address: 340 W Mt Rushmore Rd, Custer, SD 57730
Features: Free breakfast, Wi-Fi, indoor pool
Rate: \$98 USD/night (~\$135 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Roadside diner in Wyoming (~\$35 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Skogen Kitchen, Custer (~\$50 USD / ~\$69 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$135
Meals	\$104
Gas (~68L @ \$1.60/L)	\$109
Daily Total	\$348

Day 11: Tuesday, July 14, 2026

Route: Custer, SD → Sioux Falls, SD
Distance: 450 km | **Driving Time:** 4.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Revisit any Rapid City/Mount Rushmore area OR depart directly ~9:00 AM
- **En Route:** Stop at Mitchell Corn Palace (if missed earlier)
- **Afternoon:** Arrive Sioux Falls (~2:00 PM); visit Falls Park and SculptureWalk
- **Evening:** Relax at hotel

 Walking Distances — Sioux Falls

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Viewpoint	Notes
Falls Park main waterfall viewpoint	Falls Park lot	~200 m to upper viewing platform	Flat, paved
Falls Park lower level views	Same lot	~400 m to river level paths	Gentle descent
SculptureWalk, downtown	Phillips Ave parking	~50 m to first sculpture	Sculptures every 50–100 m along ~1 km of Phillips Ave; walk as far as you like

 **Tip:** The Falls Park upper platform (200 m from car) gives the best single view of all the falls at once — get that shot and you're done in under 15 minutes if needed.

Accommodation

La Quinta Inn & Suites Sioux Falls
Address: 4520 E Arrowhead Pkwy, Sioux Falls, SD 57110
Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast
Rate: \$92 USD/night (~\$127 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** En route stop (~\$30 CAD)
- **Dinner:** JL Beers, Sioux Falls — burgers & craft beer (~\$48 USD / ~\$66 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$127
Meals	\$96
Gas (~41L @ \$1.60/L)	\$66
Daily Total	\$289

Day 12: Wednesday, July 15, 2026

Route: Sioux Falls, SD → Des Moines, IA
Distance: 400 km | **Driving Time:** 4 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart Sioux Falls 9:00 AM; drive through Iowa farmland
- **Afternoon:** Arrive Des Moines (~1:00 PM); Iowa State Capitol tour (free); Pappajohn Sculpture Park (free); East Village shopping
- **Evening:** Relax at hotel

 Walking Distances — Des Moines

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Viewpoint	Notes
Iowa State Capitol exterior	Capitol lot	~100 m to main steps	Flat, paved; interior tours also available
Pappajohn Sculpture Park	Park lot on Grand Ave	~50 m to park entry	4.4-acre park; walk as little or as much as you like

Accommodation

Hampton Inn & Suites Des Moines Downtown
Address: 120 SW Water St, Des Moines, IA 50309
Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast
Rate: \$105 USD/night (~\$145 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Roadside stop (~\$28 CAD)

- **Dinner:** Zombie Burger + Drink Lab, Des Moines (~\$45 USD / ~\$62 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$145
Meals	\$90
Gas (~36L @ \$1.60/L)	\$58
Daily Total	\$293

Day 13: Thursday, July 16, 2026

Route: Des Moines, IA → Chicago, IL
Distance: 530 km | **Driving Time:** 5.5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Depart Des Moines 8:00 AM; lunch stop in Moline or Rock Island, IL
- **Afternoon:** Arrive Chicago (~2:00 PM)
 - **Millennium Park** — Cloud Gate "The Bean" (free)
 - Chicago Riverwalk
 - Navy Pier (free to walk)
- **Evening:** Dinner in Chicago; optional 360 Chicago or Skydeck Willis Tower (~\$30 USD pp / ~\$82 CAD for two)

 Walking Distances — Chicago

Attraction	Parking / Transit	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Notes
Cloud Gate "The Bean", Millennium Park	Michigan Ave garage or street	~300 m from nearest garage to Cloud Gate	Flat, paved — easy stroll
Chicago Riverwalk	Wacker Dr parking	~100 m to Riverwalk entry	Walk as far as desired; 1–3 km flat
Navy Pier entrance	Navy Pier garage	~100 m to pier entrance	Drive-up; walk along pier as desired
360 Chicago / Willis Tower Skydeck (optional)	Street or garage nearby	~100–200 m from parking	Indoor elevator — no walking concern

 **Tip:** Park once in the Grant Park / Millennium Park garages — you can walk to The Bean, Riverwalk, and waterfront all within 500 m of each other without moving the car.

Accommodation

Hampton Inn Chicago Downtown/N Loop/Michigan Ave

Address: 68 E Wacker Pl, Chicago, IL 60601
Features: Level 2 EV charging nearby, free breakfast, central location
Rate: \$145 USD/night (~\$200 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Roadside stop in Illinois (~\$30 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Giordano's or Lou Malnati's — Chicago deep dish pizza! (~\$65 USD / ~\$90 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$200
Meals	\$120
Gas (~48L @ \$1.60/L)	\$77
Optional observation deck	\$82
Parking (if needed)	\$40
Daily Total	\$437 (or \$519 with observation deck)

Day 14: Friday, July 17, 2026

Route: Chicago, IL → Kalamazoo, MI
Distance: 240 km | Driving Time: 3 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Leisurely breakfast; final walk around Chicago; optional Art Institute or Architecture River Cruise; depart 10:00 AM
- **En Route:** Drive along Lake Michigan shore through Indiana; **Indiana Dunes National Park** (optional 1–2 hour stop) — Entry included
- **Afternoon:** Arrive Kalamazoo (~2:00 PM); walk around downtown; Kalamazoo Valley Museum (free)

 Walking Distances — Day 14

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Notes
Indiana Dunes — Lake View beach	West Beach lot	~400 m to water's edge	Flat sand path
Indiana Dunes — dune overlook (optional)	West Beach or Kemil Beach lot	0.5–1 km depending on trail	Some gentle climbing — skip if tired

Attraction	Parking Location	Walk to Main Viewpoint	Notes
Kalamazoo Valley Museum	Museum lot on Kalamazoo Ave	~50 m to entrance	Indoor — no terrain concern
Downtown Kalamazoo walkabout	Burdick St parking	~100 m to main pedestrian zone	Flat, walkable

 **Tip:** At Indiana Dunes, drive to Kemil Beach instead of West Beach — shorter walk (~150 m) to a beautiful Lake Michigan shoreline with good dune views.

Accommodation

Fairfield Inn & Suites Kalamazoo

Address: 3800 Easy St, Portage, MI 49002
Features: Level 2 EV charging, free breakfast
Rate: \$95 USD/night (~\$131 CAD)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** En route in Indiana (~\$32 CAD)
- **Dinner:** Bell's Brewery, Kalamazoo — local craft brewery & pub (~\$52 USD / ~\$72 CAD for two)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$131
Meals	\$104
Gas (~22L @ \$1.60/L)	\$35
Daily Total	\$270

Day 15: Saturday, July 18, 2026

Route: Kalamazoo, MI → Hamilton, ON
Distance: 450 km | **Driving Time:** 5 hours

Attractions & Stops

- **Morning:** Final hotel breakfast; depart Kalamazoo 9:00 AM
- **En Route:** Drive through Michigan toward Canadian border; cross at Detroit/Windsor or Port Huron/Sarnia
- **Afternoon:** Arrive HOME in Hamilton! (~2:00–3:00 PM ET)

Dining

- **Breakfast:** Included at hotel
- **Lunch:** Border area or back home! (~\$25 CAD)

Daily Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost (CAD)
Meals	\$25
Gas (~41L @ \$1.60/L)	\$66
Border crossing	\$5
Daily Total	\$96

Complete Cost Breakdown Summary

Accommodation (14 nights)

Location	Nights	Total CAD
Mackinaw City, MI	1	\$131
Wisconsin Dells, WI	1	\$121
Rapid City, SD	2	\$290
Cody, WY	1	\$159
West Yellowstone, MT	3	\$572
Jackson, WY	1	\$172
Custer, SD	1	\$135
Sioux Falls, SD	1	\$127
Des Moines, IA	1	\$145
Chicago, IL	1	\$200
Kalamazoo, MI	1	\$131
TOTAL ACCOMMODATION	14	\$2,183

Meals (15 days)

Average per day: \$98 CAD
TOTAL MEALS: \$1,470 CAD

Fuel (5,700 km total)

Estimated consumption: 530 litres total
Rate: \$1.60/L CAD average
TOTAL FUEL: \$848 CAD

Park Entries & Attractions

Attraction	Cost CAD
America the Beautiful Annual Pass	\$110
Custer State Park	\$28
Crazy Horse Memorial	\$41
Buffalo Bill Center	\$58
Chicago parking (1 day)	\$40
Bridge/border tolls	\$20
Optional Wisconsin Dells tour	\$55
Optional Chicago observation deck	\$82
TOTAL ENTRIES	\$297 (or \$434 with all optional activities)

Miscellaneous

- Groceries/snacks: \$55 CAD
- Emergency fund: \$150 CAD
- **TOTAL MISC: \$205 CAD**

GRAND TOTAL COST

Category	Cost (CAD)
Accommodation	\$2,183
Meals	\$1,470
Fuel	\$848
Attractions/Entries	\$297
Miscellaneous	\$205
TOTAL	\$5,003 CAD
Per Person	\$2,502 CAD
Cost per day	~\$334 CAD

With all optional activities: ~\$5,140 CAD total

Walking Distance Master Summary

This section provides a at-a-glance reference of walking effort across all key attraction days.

Day	Location	Min. Walking (m)	Notes
Day 4	Mount Rushmore, Custer SP, Crazy Horse	~700 m	All flat/paved if avoiding Presidential Trail
Day 5	Badlands + Devils Tower	~400–900 m	Drive-up overlooks dominate; one optional boardwalk
Day 7	Yellowstone Lower Loop	~3,500 m	All flat boardwalks; spread across full day
Day 8	Yellowstone Upper Loop	~1,800 m	Porcelain Basin + Mammoth Lower Terraces + Artist Point
Day 9	Grand Teton	~540 m	Five iconic viewpoints, all under 200 m from parking
Day 13	Chicago	~700 m	Bean + Riverwalk + Navy Pier vicinity

Total walking across all major sightseeing days: approximately 8–9 km spread across 6 days — well under 2 km per day on average.

Important Notes & Tips

National Parks Pass

- **America the Beautiful Annual Pass:** \$80 USD (~\$110 CAD)
- Covers 1 vehicle and all passengers — perfect for couples!
- Valid at: Yellowstone, Grand Teton, Badlands, Wind Cave, Devils Tower, Mount Rushmore, Indiana Dunes
- Purchase at first park (Badlands on Day 5) or buy online beforehand at store.usgs.gov/recreationpass
- Physical pass ships within 3 weeks — allow time or buy at park
- Keep pass in glove box for easy access at park entrances

EV Charging Strategy for Mitsubishi Outlander PHEV

- PHEV charging planned at: Mackinaw City, Rapid City, Cody, West Yellowstone (3 nights), Sioux Falls, Des Moines, Chicago, Kalamazoo
- All Level 2 overnight charging at hotels (220V, 3–5 hour full charge)
- Cost: Most hotel chargers are complimentary or \$5–10 per session
- Can run hybrid mode continuously if needed — don't worry about charging gaps
- ChargePoint and PlugShare apps — find public charging stations en route
- Electric range: ~35–40 km per charge; use for city driving to save gas
- **Tip:** Request room near charging station when checking in

Peak Summer Crowds (July)

- July is **peak tourist season** across all parks — expect crowds every day, not just holidays
- Yellowstone: Arrive at each site before 8:00 AM to beat parking congestion

- Grand Teton: Snake River Overlook, Jenny Lake, and Mormon Row are extremely popular — go early or late afternoon
- Badlands: Much lighter crowds than Yellowstone; mornings are still best
- **Start early every day** — the difference between a stress-free visit and a chaotic one is arriving before 9 AM

Money-Saving Tips

1. **Hotel breakfasts:** All hotels include free breakfast — saves \$20–30/day CAD
2. **Pack lunches:** Buy groceries for in-park days (bread, deli meat, cheese, fruit, snacks)
3. **Gas apps:** Use GasBuddy or Waze for cheapest gas stations (can save \$10–20/tank)
4. **Annual Pass:** Saves \$70+ USD vs buying individual park entries
5. **Off-peak dining:** Eat lunch as main meal (dinner prices are 20–30% higher)
6. **Free water:** Refill bottles at park visitor centres instead of buying
7. **Group discounts:** Ask about CAA/AAA discounts at hotels and attractions
8. **Credit card rewards:** Use travel rewards card for USD purchases (check foreign transaction fees)

Border Crossing Tips

Entering USA (Day 1):

- Bring passports (REQUIRED — no exceptions)
- NEXUS cards if you have them (use NEXUS lanes for faster processing)
- Border wait times: Check cbp.gov/bwt before crossing
- Best crossing points: Ambassador Bridge (Detroit/Windsor) or Blue Water Bridge (Port Huron/Sarnia)
- Peak wait times: Weekdays 7–9 AM, 4–6 PM; Weekends 10 AM–4 PM
- Have hotel address ready for first night
- Declare all food items (no fresh fruits/vegetables allowed into USA)
- **July 4 tip:** Cross early (before 8 AM) — Independence Day brings heavier border traffic

Returning to Canada (Day 15):

- Duty-free exemption after 48+ hours: \$800 CAD per person
- Declare ALL purchases (receipts ready)
- Alcohol limit: 1.5L wine OR 1.14L spirits OR 8.5L beer per person
- ArriveCAN — check current requirements before trip at cbsa-asfc.gc.ca

Weather Considerations (Early–Mid July)

- **Yellowstone elevations:** 2,000–3,000m (6,500–9,800 ft)
- Temperature ranges:
 - Yellowstone: 5–25°C days, -2 to 5°C nights
 - South Dakota: 20–30°C days, 10–15°C nights
 - Chicago: 22–28°C, humid
- Afternoon thunderstorms common in mountains (2–4 PM) — plan to be back at car by 2 PM
- Snow possible at high elevations even in July
- Layering is key: Start day with jacket, strip to t-shirt by noon
- UV intensity is significantly stronger at high elevation (SPF 50+ essential)
- Wildfire season: Check air quality forecasts at [AirNow.gov](https://airnow.gov)

Vehicle Preparation & Road Trip Essentials

Pre-departure vehicle inspection:

- Oil change if due within trip dates
- Check tire pressure and tread depth (including spare)
- Top off all fluids (coolant, brake fluid, windshield washer)
- Test lights, wipers, horn; check battery health
- Verify PHEV charging cable is in vehicle

Emergency car kit:

- Jumper cables, tire inflator/sealant, flashlight with extra batteries
- Basic tool kit, duct tape, ice scraper (even in summer — high elevations!)
- Tow rope
- CAA/AAA membership: Verify coverage extends to USA

Cell Phone Coverage — Know the Dead Zones

Good coverage: All major cities and highways, I-90 corridor in South Dakota, Chicago area, Michigan

Spotty/No coverage: Yellowstone (60% of park has no service — Verizon best), Grand Teton (limited to main roads), rural Wyoming (large gaps between towns), Badlands (visitor centres only)

Solutions:

- Download offline maps for entire route
- Screenshot hotel addresses/phone numbers
- Print physical itinerary
- Let family know you may be unreachable for days at a time

Food Storage & Wildlife Safety — CRITICAL

Wildlife Distance Rules:

- 25 metres (75 feet): Bison, elk, deer, moose, bighorn sheep
- 100 metres (300 feet): Bears, wolves, coyotes
- Use zoom lens for photos — NOT zoom feet!

Food Storage in Parks:

- Never leave food in open vehicle
- Store in hard-sided containers or trunk
- Use bear-proof trash cans
- Don't eat in car then leave windows down

If Wildlife Approaches:

- Stay calm, don't run; back away slowly
- Get in vehicle if available
- Bear spray only as last resort (within 7–10m)

Driving Safety — Mountain & Rural Roads

- Speed limits: Strictly enforced in national parks (45 mph / 70 km/h max)
- Many mountain roads have sharp hairpin turns (10–20 mph / 15–30 km/h)
- Use low gear on descents to avoid brake fade
- Wildlife crossings: Dawn/dusk most dangerous — scan roadsides constantly
- In Wyoming, gas stations can be 100+ km apart — fill at half tank

Health & Safety

Altitude Sickness:

- Yellowstone is 2,300m (7,500 ft)
- Symptoms: Headache, nausea, fatigue, dizziness
- Prevention: Hydrate (3–4L water/day), avoid alcohol first 24h, rest frequently

Medical Facilities in Yellowstone:

- Clinics at Mammoth, Old Faithful, Lake (May–Sept only)
- Emergency: Dial 911 from any park phone
- Nearest hospitals: Jackson (WY), Cody (WY), Bozeman (MT)

Top 15 Must-See Sites — No Hiking Required

All accessible via car, short walks, or wheelchair-accessible boardwalks:

1. **Grand Prismatic Spring, Yellowstone** — Easy boardwalk loop, most photographed thermal feature
2. **Old Faithful Geyser, Yellowstone** — View from benches, erupts every ~90 minutes
3. **Grand Canyon of Yellowstone — Artist Point** — Paved 150 m path to iconic waterfall view
4. **Mount Rushmore** — View from Grand View Terrace, 250 m from parking
5. **Badlands Overlooks** — 13 scenic pullouts along Loop Road, all roadside
6. **Mammoth Hot Springs Terraces** — Easy boardwalk loops + drive-through upper terraces
7. **Devils Tower** — View from 200 m paved path from parking area
8. **Mormon Row Barns, Grand Teton** — Drive-up photo ops with mountain backdrop
9. **Cloud Gate ("The Bean"), Chicago** — Walk around mirrored sculpture in Millennium Park
10. **Crazy Horse Memorial** — View from visitor centre terrace, 100 m from parking
11. **Wildlife Loop Road, Custer State Park** — 18-mile scenic drive to see bison herds
12. **Hayden Valley, Yellowstone** — Wildlife viewing from pullouts (bison, elk, bears)
13. **Needles Highway, South Dakota** — Scenic drive through granite spires with tunnels
14. **West Thumb Geyser Basin** — Lakeside boardwalk with colourful hot springs, 0.9 km flat loop
15. **Snake River Overlook, Grand Teton** — Famous Ansel Adams viewpoint, roadside pullout

Pre-Trip Checklist

3 Months Before (By April 4, 2026)

- ☐ Book all 14 hotel accommodations (especially West Yellowstone for peak July)
- ☐ Purchase America the Beautiful Annual Pass online (optional — can buy at first park)

- ☐ Research and book travel insurance
- ☐ Check passport expiry dates (must be valid through January 2027)
- ☐ Apply for NEXUS cards if interested
- ☐ Book any special dining reservations (Chicago deep dish restaurants)

1 Month Before (By June 4, 2026)

- ☐ Confirm all hotel reservations via email/phone
- ☐ Schedule Outlander PHEV service (oil change, tire rotation, multi-point inspection)
- ☐ Check vehicle insurance covers USA travel; verify CAA membership covers USA
- ☐ Download: Yellowstone NPS app, GasBuddy, PlugShare, SpotHero
- ☐ Order physical road atlas as backup
- ☐ Check for road closures (WYDOT, SDDOT) and park alerts (nps.gov/yell)
- ☐ Set credit card travel notifications (July 4 – July 18, USA)

2 Weeks Before (By June 20, 2026)

- ☐ Complete vehicle service/maintenance
- ☐ Download offline maps: Michigan, Wisconsin, South Dakota, Wyoming, Montana, Iowa, Illinois, Indiana, Grand Teton, Yellowstone NPS
- ☐ Purchase road trip snacks (non-perishable)
- ☐ Start breaking in walking shoes if new

1 Week Before (By June 27, 2026)

- ☐ Final hotel confirmation calls (especially West Yellowstone)
- ☐ Print entire itinerary as backup; print hotel addresses and phone numbers
- ☐ Pack bags; test all electronics; charge all devices fully
- ☐ Wash car and clean interior; check tire pressure (including spare)
- ☐ Prepare "car kit" (first aid, flashlight, emergency supplies)
- ☐ Buy cooler; purchase reusable water bottles; stock car snacks
- ☐ Notify neighbours/family of travel dates; arrange mail/newspaper hold
- ☐ Withdraw USD cash (\$200–300)

Day Before Departure (Friday, July 3, 2026)

- ☐ Full tank of gas; fully charge PHEV battery
- ☐ Check all tire pressures (including spare); test all lights; clean windshield
- ☐ Load luggage into vehicle (leave room for souvenirs!)
- ☐ Set up phone mounts/chargers in car; pack cooler with drinks and snacks
- ☐ Double-check passports are packed
- ☐ Final home check: lights off, thermostat adjusted, stove off, windows/doors locked, garage closed
- ☐ Set alarms for 7:00 AM (depart by 9:00 AM)
- ☐ Get good night's sleep!

Departure Morning (Saturday, July 4, 2026)

- ☐ Quick breakfast at home; fill coffee thermoses
- ☐ Final house walkthrough; set home security

- ☐ Take photo of odometer (track mileage)
- ☐ Plug in phone navigation; review Day 1 route
- **Departure time: 9:00 AM ET — Let's go!**

During Trip — Daily Checklist

- ☐ Check weather for next day each evening
- ☐ Charge all electronics overnight
- ☐ Charge PHEV at hotel (if available)
- ☐ Review next day's route before bed
- ☐ Keep receipts organised
- ☐ Refill water bottles; restock car snacks
- ☐ Stretch legs every 2 hours of driving
- ☐ Stay hydrated (especially at altitude)

Return Home (Saturday, July 18) — Post-Trip

- ☐ Unload vehicle; unpack; do laundry
- ☐ Download photos from camera and back up to cloud
- ☐ Calculate actual trip costs vs budget
- ☐ Share photos with family/friends!
- ☐ Schedule post-trip vehicle inspection if needed

Emergency Contacts

Contact	Number
USA Emergency	911
Yellowstone Dispatch	307-344-7381
CAA Roadside Assistance	1-800-222-4357
Poison Control (USA)	1-800-222-1222
Canadian Consulate Chicago	312-616-1860

Alternative Options to Consider

If You Want to Cut 1 Day: Skip Des Moines stop (Day 12) — go directly Chicago from Sioux Falls (~650 km). Saves 1 accommodation night (~\$145 CAD). Total trip: 14 days instead of 15.

If You Want MORE Chicago Time: Add extra night in Chicago (2 nights total). Visit: Art Institute, Field Museum, Shedd Aquarium, Navy Pier, Architecture tour. Cost: +\$200 accommodation, +\$100 meals = +\$300 CAD total.

If Budget is Tight: Skip optional activities (Wisconsin Dells tour, Chicago observation deck) — saves \$137 CAD. Pack more meals — saves \$200–300 CAD. Could reduce total to ~\$4,200–4,400 CAD.

If You Want More Nature, Less Cities: Skip Chicago overnight (save \$200). Add second night in Jackson, WY for extra Grand Teton time.

Trip Statistics

Stat	Detail
Total Distance	5,700 km
Days	15 (14 nights)
States Visited	9 (Michigan, Wisconsin, Minnesota, South Dakota, Wyoming, Montana, Iowa, Illinois, Indiana)
National Parks	Badlands, Wind Cave, Devils Tower, Grand Teton, Yellowstone, Indiana Dunes
Average Daily Cost	~\$334 CAD
Total Estimated Cost	~\$5,003 CAD (\$2,502/person)

All prices are estimates based on 2026 projections. Actual costs may vary. Gas prices fluctuate — budget accordingly. Book accommodations early for July peak season.

Updated: June 2026 — Trip dates revised to July 4–18, 2026. Walking distances and optimization tips added throughout.

Have an amazing trip! Safe travels! 🚗 ✨ 🏡